DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

How Does Evil End in Good?

Daat Tevunot, Summary

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** Summary of §125-133 (Section 6), with a review of Sections 1-2 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Monday 12 June 2023

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Why a revision class

Sections 5 and 6 were what the Rabbi called "a detour" into the details of evil. Before Section 7 opens a new topic, the class went through the summary of Section 6 in the English edition and then began reviewing the first sections of the book, so the whole structure is fresh.

Part 1: debasement and destruction

The Ramhal identifies two effects of evil: debasement and actual destruction.

Debasement applies only to man. Something that exists at its proper level, however low, is not debased. Animals are not debased. They are on their own level. Man is debased because he is lower than he should be. The Rabbi explained that before the sin Adam was not debased either. He was on level 2, his proper level for that stage. He was created there, rather than on level 1, precisely so that he could go either up or down. He chose down.

Destruction applies to everything physical, animals included. Everything material ends, "even the sun". Adam in Gan Eden was not yet subject to destruction but was already open to the possibility of it. That is the meaning of "on the day you eat from it you will die". He did not die that day, but as the Ramban explains, he became mortal, part of a world in which everything physical comes to an end.

Every part of creation is linked, with man as the "dynamic factor". The power of a deed depends on three things: who you are, what you are doing (a misvah has more power than any other act), and how you do it.

Gan Eden is real, but it is not Olam Haba

Before the sin Adam's form was splendid, close to that of angels, and his home was Gan Eden. Its trees were real trees and the eating was real eating, but refined beyond what we can picture. The tree of life gave knowledge and closeness to God, and the tree of knowledge brought base desires. After the sin Adam had to leave, because a level 3 person can no longer live in a level 2 environment.

A participant pointed out that Gan Eden is lower than Olam Haba, and the Rabbi agreed. In Olam Haba there is still a refined physical body, but there is no longer any ability to sin, and that is level 1. Gan Eden in Bereshit was level 2, where sin was still possible. That is why, after death today, the soul goes to Gan Eden, which is only a "taste" of Olam Haba. The Rabbi called it "the waiting room". Adam in Gan Eden was in a waiting room too, waiting to see whether he would rise to Olam Haba or fall to this world.

Part 2: destruction comes from disconnection

On the surface the world looks scattered, but looked at more deeply it is all joined in one purpose, the revelation of God's glory. Imperfection and destruction come from a lack of connection and unity between the parts. When the divine emanations are united, blessing flows. When they are separated, destruction follows.

What decides between unity and separation is the relationship between Israel and Hashem, who longs for us like a husband for the wife of his youth and a father for his son. The Rabbi linked this to the last blessing of the Amidah, "Sim shalom... uverakhah". Shalom comes from shalem, complete. Berakhah flows when everything is complete and connected.

Part 3: good is never totally destroyed

Hashem never meant destruction to be permanent, so He decreed that a trace always remains. The examples are the seed that rots and sprouts again, the luz bone from which the body will be rebuilt at the resurrection, and Israel, brought down to the dust in exile but never abandoned, "like a newly budding vine". Even death, the worst destruction, contains something good, and that is the model for everything else.

Part 4: evil pushed down

The first emanation was dimmed to allow evil, and the second emanation holds it back. On each of the ten levels the good is established and the evil pushed down, until all evil is gathered at the lowest level. That is why Hashem's measure of good is far greater than His measure of punishment. When Israel strengthen the good, the wicked are brought low. When they sin, the wicked are strengthened. "That's the purpose of the misvot and our task in the world: to bring the evil further and further down until it's totally nullified."

The plan for the rest of the book

There are ten sections. Sections 7, 8 and 9 form one big topic: how Hashem runs the world while evil exists. Section 10 is a new subject.

Review: Sections 1 and 2

Section 1 is the purpose of creation and of man. God wanted to give the greatest good, which is closeness to Him (devekut). That cannot simply be handed over. It has to be earned, so man was made imperfect, with the task of perfecting himself. The way God made the world imperfect was by concealing His infinite essence, which leads into Section 2.

Section 2 is about Yihud: there is nothing in the world except Hashem, and nothing can oppose His will. Since we cannot grasp any positive attribute of an infinite God, the one thing we can grasp fully is a negative, that no other power exists. To show this, evil must exist for a time and then be destroyed, in two phases: the 6,000 years, and then the eternal world of reward. Adam could have revealed this by his own merit. Instead he sinned, so man must experience the full force of evil until the redemption.

The Rabbi ended with the prayer of Yom Kippur that all evil will vanish like smoke. A room full of smoke looks full, "but there's nothing actually there".

Summary

- Debasement applies only to man, who is below his proper level. Destruction applies to everything physical.
- Gan Eden was real but on level 2. It is not Olam Haba, and today it is the "waiting room" before Olam Haba.
- Unity brings blessing and disconnection brings destruction. This depends on Israel's relationship with Hashem.
- A trace of good always remains, and evil is pushed down level by level until it disappears.
- Sections 1 and 2: man perfects himself to earn closeness to God, and the means is the temporary existence of evil and the final revelation of Yihud.

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